

THE WORLD WARS

World War II: The Allied Victory

World War II: The Allied Victory examines the course of events of the Second World War which led to the final success of the Allies in 1945. For the first three years, neither the Allied troops nor their opponents could deliver a decisive blow in

battle. But Allied fortunes in the Mediterranean and the Pacific and Hitler's disaster in Russia opened the way for the long planned invasion of Normandy in 1944. Finally, decisive victory in Europe seemed to be within the Allies' grasp. But then what kept Hitler from surrendering when defeat seemed so inevitable? What tactics were used by the Americans to gain military supremacy in the Pacific? And what part did the atom bomb play in forcing Japan's surrender? These questions are examined alongside the analysis of the political and military consequences of the Second World War and the way it has shaped our lives to this day.

The author, Sean Sheehan, has a degree in Ancient History. He has taught English and history and has been interested in World War II since childhood. He has also written two books for Hodder Wayland about the Holocaust.



The consultant, Dr. Niall J.A. Barr, is a Senior Lecturer in the Department of War Studies at R. M. A. Sandhurst. He is an expert in the development and history of the British veterans' movement and has a deep interest in the military history of both World Wars.

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The Allied Victory — Sean Sheehan

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Sean Sheehan



THE WORLD WARS

Beginning and End

After every war
someone has to clear up.
For things won't find their right place
on their own.

Someone has to heave
the rubble to the roadsides
so the carts piled high with corpses
can pass by.

Photogenic it certainly isn't;
and it takes years.
All the cameras have gone off
to other wars.

Those who knew
what this was all about
must make way for those
who know little, or less than a little,
or simply nothing.

Wisława Szymborska from
Koniec I początku

(*Beginning and End*, translated from
Polish)



*The Americans thought it would take four days
before they could fly their flag over the volcanic
island of Iwo Jima. In fact, it took many weeks
of heavy and bitter fighting.*

Iwo Jima and Okinawa

The capture of two Pacific islands, Iwo Jima and Okinawa, in the first half of 1945, represented a tightening of the noose around Japan. Their capture signalled the end of Japan's ability to withstand the military might of the USA. The 20 sq km that made up Iwo Jima was defended, trench by trench, by 20,000 Japanese soldiers who had dug in with the intention of fighting to the death. Over 25,000 Americans were killed before the island was cleared in March, and its strategic value was put to immediate use when B-29 Superfortresses landed on an emergency runway. Eventually, half the island became one giant airport from where bombing raids on Japan were launched.

The campaign to capture Okinawa began on the first day of April, and it lasted nearly three months.



*A reef is dynamited near
Okinawa in the Pacific in order
to provide a landing place for
supply ships. Five days after the
capture of the island, the Allies
called for the surrender of Japan
or face 'prompt and utter
destruction.'*

When the island was finally captured, Americans were able to use Okinawa as a safe anchorage from which to blockade the Japanese mainland and prevent any supplies reaching the country. As with Saipan, the island of Okinawa was bitterly defended by the Japanese who had prepared their positions on the island and employed kamikaze attacks on enemy ships. Over 100,000 Japanese were killed before the island was cleared, but it required a mammoth amount of military hardware to accomplish the task. Over 90,000 missions were flown by American aircraft in the course of the Okinawa campaign, and more petrol and oil was used up than Japan imported for the whole of the previous year. Together, the two islands cost more American lives than the D-Day invasion of Normandy.

'The greatest thing in history'

While the war in Europe was drawing to a close, the Americans were pondering how best to bring the war in Asia to an end. The losses

incurred in the capture of Iwo Jima and Okinawa made the task of a military conquest of the Japanese mainland seem daunting indeed. Although the Japanese were not in a position to win, the Americans did not immediately know how seriously weakened was the enemy. In fact, Japan was on her knees and close to collapse, with two-thirds of her commercial fleet at the bottom of the sea and severe shortages of food and raw materials.

The B-29 Superfortresses were now able to bomb Japanese cities and, in one single raid on a residential area of southern Tokyo in March 1945, over 80,000 people were killed. What was also likely to accelerate the end of the conflict was Russia's agreement to join the war against Japan within months of defeating Germany. At first, the USA was keen to encourage this because it promised to hasten the end of the war and save American lives.



The B-29 Superfortress

The B-29 Superfortress was an aircraft designed and built for the purpose of mass destruction from the air. They were first ready to fly by the middle of 1944 and were used to bomb selected targets in Japan before the end of the year but with very little success. Then, instead of deploying conventional bombs, the B-29s were used to drop incendiaries (fire bombs). The use of incendiaries on the densely-packed streets of Japanese cities, where most homes were built of wood, was catastrophic. When the B-29s took off on large-scale fire-bombing of Tokyo the planes were stripped of most of their defensive armaments to increase the quantity of incendiaries they could carry. The raid lasted over two hours, it took nearly three weeks to bury the dead and a million people were left homeless.

US Bombing raids on Japan using the B-29 Superfortress (at front of photo) had devastating effects and, by the end of June 1945, Japan's war industry was effectively destroyed. The first indications that the country might surrender were made in July.

By early August, when the collapse of Japan seemed more likely and atom bombs were ready to use, America's attitude towards Russia changed. The USA now preferred to try and bring the war to an end on its own. By this time, Russia was keen to join in the Pacific war and receive its share of the spoils.

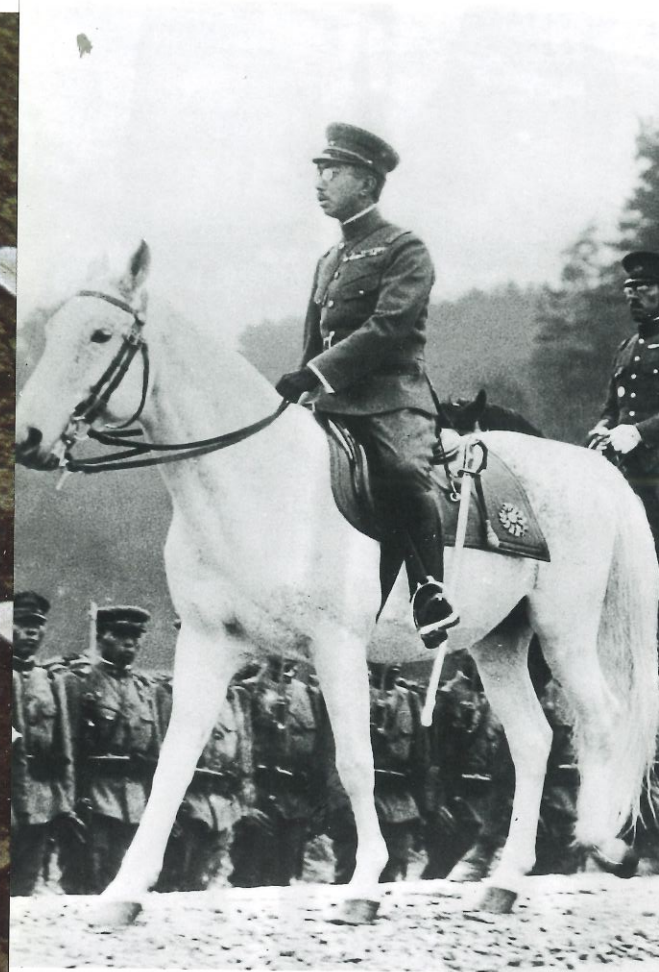
Towards the end of July, the Potsdam Declaration, which did not involve Russia, called upon Japan to surrender unconditionally or face complete and immediate destruction. At this stage, there was no assurance that the monarchy and the Emperor would escape punishment. Nor were the Japanese aware of their enemy's secret weapon.

America's secret weapon was the successful development of atom bombs, the result of a project that had been focused for three years on the task of controlling a nuclear explosion. Bombs were ready by the middle of 1945 and, after a successful test in New Mexico in July, an atomic bomb was dropped on the city of Hiroshima on 6 August. The plane was blessed by a priest before it took off with its deadly cargo.

Over 70,000 civilians were killed almost immediately, with many thousands dying later from burns and forms of cancer. Roosevelt had died earlier in the year, and when President Harry Truman received the news of Hiroshima he exclaimed, 'This is the greatest thing in history.' A second bomb was later dropped on the city of Nagasaki, with equally horrific consequences.



A mushroom cloud over the city of Hiroshima signalled the dropping of an atomic bomb from a B-29 Superfortress named the Enola Gay. The chief pilot said he could only see 'a black boiling debris down below'.



Emperor Hirohito (1901–89) played an important role in the surrender of Japan but details of the circumstances surrounding the act of surrender continue to emerge and the full story has yet to be told.

Enduring the unendurable

Japan's surrender was announced by Emperor Hirohito when he broadcast by radio to his people that 'the unendurable must be endured'. The dropping of the atom bombs and the circumstances around the surrender of Japan have remained a controversial topic ever since the Second World War came to an end.

The Japanese government was split between hardline military leaders, who wanted to fight the Americans on Japanese soil and then negotiate for better surrender terms, and another larger group who saw the hopelessness of the situation and were anxious to make peace. Peace proposals were made to Russia, which were intercepted and read by the USA, but they came to nothing. Even after the Hiroshima bomb, some military leaders were only prepared to call a ceasefire if the Allies promised not to occupy Japan.

It was the Emperor who settled the matter by insisting on surrender, having received an assurance from the Americans that the monarchy would not be dismantled by the victors. This assurance was never stated in so many words but the American statement, made through the neutral Swiss government, that the future government of Japan would be chosen by 'the freely expressed will of the Japanese people' amounted to the same thing.

At the last moment, before the Emperor made his radio broadcast, a small group of militarists tried to seize the imperial palace and prevent the broadcast being made. The attempt failed and the leaders of the revolt



committed suicide, preferring death to what they saw as a deep dishonour. The main, formal surrender took place in Tokyo Bay on 2 September 1945. In total, over 20 million Japanese people were killed, injured or made homeless during the war. The Second World War was over in Asia.

General MacArthur is saluted after the formal surrender of Japan is signed aboard the US battleship Missouri. The Second World War had finally come to an end.

Unheroic facts

Desertion from the army: About 100,000 cases of desertion occurred in the British army and a similar rate applied to the US army, mostly amongst infantry troops who experienced the trauma of combat.

Military trials: The USA charged 1.7 million men with breaches of discipline and 142 were executed. Over 200,000 courts martial took place in the British army.

Avoiding air combat: As many as 25 per cent of planes in some RAF (Royal Air Force) squadrons returned early from raids over Germany claiming unlikely technical faults and similar events occurred in the US Army Air Force (USAAF). Deliberately landing in a neutral country where crews were interned as prisoners also took place.